

Passages - White Nights

Or was his destiny from the start
To be but just one moment
Near your heart?

'Twas a wonderful night, such a night as is
only possible when we are young

in one instant she becomes, as though by
chance, inexplicably lovely and exquisite,
and, impressed and intoxicated, one
cannot help asking oneself what power
made those sad, pensive eyes flash with
such fire? What summoned the blood to
those pale, wan cheeks? What bathed with
passion those soft features? What set that
bosom heaving? What so suddenly called
strength, life and beauty into the poor
girl's face, making it gleam with such a
smile, kindle with such bright, sparkling
laughter? You look round, you seek for
someone, you conjecture ... But the
moment passes, and next day you meet,
maybe, the same pensive and preoccupied
look as before, the same pale face, the
same meek and timid movements, and
even signs of remorse, traces of a mortal
anguish and regret for the fleeting
distraction ... And you grieve that the
momentary beauty has faded so soon
never to return, that it flashed upon you so
treacherously, so vainly, grieve because
you had not even time to love her . . .

I am a dreamer; I have so little real life that
I look upon such moments as this now as
so rare that I cannot help going over such
moments again in my dreams. I shall be
dreaming of you all night, a whole week, a
whole year.

At this moment, Nastenka, when we have

met at last after such a long separation - for I have known you for ages, Nastenka, because I have been looking for someone for ages, and that is a sign that it was you I was looking for, and it was ordained that we should meet now - at this moment a thousand valves have opened in my head, and I must let myself flow in a river of words, or I shall choke.

What torments they suffered, what agonies of terror, how innocent, how pure was their love, and how (I need hardly say, Nastenka) malicious people were! And, good heavens! surely he met her afterwards, far from their native shores, under alien skies, in the hot south in the divinely eternal city, in the dazzling splendour of the ball to the crash of music, in a palazzo (it must be in a palazzo), drowned in a sea of lights, on the balcony, wreathed in myrtle and roses, where, recognising him, she hurriedly removes her mask and whispering, "I am free," flings herself trembling into his arms, and with a cry of rapture, clinging to one another, in one instant they forget their sorrow and their parting and all their agonies, and the gloomy house and the old man and the dismal garden in that distant land, and the seat on which with a last passionate kiss she tore herself away from his arms numb with anguish and despair . . .

I cried, unable to restrain my feelings longer. "And I realise now, more than ever, that I have lost all my best years! And now I know it and feel it more painfully from recognising that God has sent me you, my good angel, to tell me that and show it. Now that I sit beside you and talk to you it is strange for me to think of the future, for in the future - there is loneliness again, again this musty, useless life; and what

shall I have to dream of when I have been so happy in reality beside you! Oh, may you be blessed, dear girl, for not having repulsed me at first, for enabling me to say that for two evenings - at least, I have lived.

You know it will be sad to be left alone, utterly alone, and to have not even anything to regret - nothing, absolutely nothing ... for all that you have lost, all that, all was nothing, stupid, simple nullity, there has been nothing but dreams!

How blind you are, Nastenka! ... Oh, how unbearable a happy person is sometimes! But I could not be angry with you!'

Oh. Nastenka, Nastenka! If only you knew how lonely I am now!

My God, a whole moment of happiness! Is that too little for the whole of a man's life?